

Parent TRAP

As they attempt to create an army of starboys and supergirls, projecting onto them their own ambitions, parents find themselves under attack

| By Prachi Rege and Gunjeet Sra |

Whether it is celebrity judge Saroj Khan admonishing a parent for dressing up a 10-year-old boy as a girl to have a better shot at winning the reality show, *Chak Dhoom Dhoom*, or professional drama queen Rakhi Sawant publicly

distancing herself from her mother on one show, only to forgive her on another, toxic parents have become the flavour of the season. Take the Volkswagen ad where the child exhibits frighteningly mature killer instincts, the put-upon child of the Max New York Life ad whose parents fight over him when he declares he came first in class or the Rasna ad where a girl takes on a battery-operated bear and an Egyptian mummy. Take also box office hits such as *Wake Up Sid* and *3 Idiots* which show parents in evil goblin light, either ignoring their sensibilities or wilfully subverting them. Its most extreme form is to be found on television where every night, a child either contorts his body in an approximation of adult dance moves in a reality show or is tortured for TRPs in a soap. Once the unquestioned icons at the centre of family life, the self-sacrificing mummy and the proud papa are no longer as altruistic as they once seemed.

Mommy Dearest

PREPARING THEIR CHILDREN FOR A LIFE LIVED IN THE SPOTLIGHT

The mummy was once a fixture of film sets and a figure of fun in movie magazines, always accompanying her daughter, keeping a watchful eye on her love life and waistline. She's now taken



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SHILPA BUDHRAJA WITH SON JAYADITYA



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over television as well, and often begins with children younger than ever. Take the case of Saloni Daini, 8, the youngest contestant and winner of the comedy show *Chhote Miyan*. Saloni was introduced to show business by her mother Sanyogita, 37, a homemaker, at the suggestion of a director of a reality show. She shot a portfolio of her daughter, who immediately bagged an ad at the age of four. It was enough incentive for the Dainis to shift base from Kolhapur to Mumbai. "Thankfully, my husband has a transferable job, otherwise I'd have shifted with Saloni," says the proud mother. From hosting the show *Chak Dhoom Dhoom* to Amol Palekar's movie *Doomkarta* where she plays Sushmita Sen's daughter, Saloni rehearses for three days in a week after school, for five hours a day and begins studying 20 days before her exams. It's worth it. While a beginner child star earns between Rs 3,000 and Rs 5,000 a